



This is electrifying

Venezuela experiences a natural phenomenon of lightning-only storms that occurs 160 nights in a year. <http://digit.in/lightning>



Trends in telecom, acquisitions and more

Nigel Eastwood, CEO, New Call Telecom shares his thoughts on trends in the Indian telecom industry. Supplementing New Call's growth strategy, we're also privy to insights from Vikas Saxena, CEO, Nimbuzz and Sanjeev Bobby Sarin, Founder, Ozone



▲ From l-r: Nigel Eastwood, Vikas Saxena and Sanjeev Bobby Sarin

d There seems to be a resurgence of VoIP in the industry now that WhatsApp has jumped on to the bandwagon as well. What are your thoughts on that?

Nigel: If you think about it, VoIP's been around for a decade. In fact, some of the first VoIP technology was launched in 2006 – it's not a new phenomenon. Actually, in the west, VoIP has been utilised quite a lot for business over the last 3-5 years. Suddenly, these big tech giants think they've found the new great thing when it's been around for ages.

If you actually review the way that people communicate via Facebook, WhatsApp or other messaging platforms, it's been about replacing SMS over the last 3-5 years. But suddenly now people realise voice isn't going away. If you look at emerging markets now, you'll realise that people still want to talk. Also, look at the average small business operator, voice is still the way they do business and will continue to for many years to come. Even the average SMB (Small and Medium Business) here in India – there are maybe 50 million of them – has a mobile number associated with its retail outlet. There's no hashtag or mention of Twitter or Facebook. It's all on voice. It's the same in Africa, and generally across emerging markets in Asia – that trend isn't going away.

d What will be the top trends in telecom that will affect users in the near future, either positive or negative?

Nigel: As we've seen in India, e-commerce or as I call it "the flipkart-isation of India" almost over the last two years has led to people finally awakening to the idea of acquiring goods over the internet. That has led to a whole new range of business models – from furniture to lingerie.

Areas that I see trending are also committed to disrupting the traditional business models, i.e. banking and fintech with the emergence of things revolving around peer-to-peer lending and mobile wallets.

Fintech has just started to take a good foothold across the world – so that's one to watch.

Content, in all its forms, is now being driven more and more online. In the west, we see lots of platforms really starting to challenge the big goliaths – the big cable operators. The Netflix model (the video-on-demand model) is certainly the new trend.

Traditionally, the millennial generation isn't at all interested in set-top-boxes or viewing content via satellite. These models will proliferate again. The process of con-

suming video data is now called "snacking". So you take a little bit of data at home, you jump on the metro, you view your favourite soap opera on the train for 15 minutes while you get to work, you get to office and at lunch continue watching. It's all synced. The viewing media has gone down from 32 inches to less than 10 inches. This model will be very dominant moving forward.

No matter what we're doing in the digital world, we leave our digital thumbprint. Things related to Big Data, data security, national identification, all of these e-govt initiatives will start to create more jobs, more opportunities as we move forward. Collaboration, the Dropbox-type interface, is becoming more and more apparent as businesses seem to want to drive more virtual operations, to have virtual teams working across India in collaboration without the cumbersome overheads of occupancy of offices. The home-working phenomenon is certainly there and the types of collaborative software that are being released really help. We've seen big valuations over the last few months.

If we look at India and the Modi government focusing on areas to really improve